

Best Exercises for Hip Arthritis: A Physiotherapist-Approved

Hip arthritis limits mobility and independence. These evidence-based exercises can reduce pain, strengthen muscles, and improve your daily life.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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The hip is one of the most commonly affected joints in osteoarthritis, with over **4.7 million** people in the UK experiencing hip pain. Exercise is consistently recommended by NICE as a core treatment — yet many people avoid it, fearing it will cause more damage.

The truth: Appropriate exercise does not wear out arthritic joints. It strengthens the muscles that support them, improves flexibility, and reduces pain.

Before You Start

- Mild discomfort during exercise is normal; sharp pain is not — stop if you feel it
- Warm up with 5 minutes of gentle walking or marching on the spot
- Aim for consistency over intensity: 10–15 minutes daily beats 60 minutes once a week
- Consult your GP or physiotherapist if you're post-surgery or have severe symptoms



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Strengthening Exercises

****1. Bridging**** Lie on your back, knees bent, feet flat. Squeeze your glutes and lift your hips until your body forms a straight line from shoulders to knees. Hold for 5 seconds. Lower slowly. - Reps: 10–12, 2 sets - Targets: Gluteus maximus, core stability - Why it helps: Weak glutes are the number one contributor to hip pain

****2. Side-Lying Hip Abduction**** Lie on your side with legs straight. Lift the top leg to about 30°, keeping it straight and toes pointing forward (not up). Hold 3 seconds. Lower slowly. - Reps: 10 each side, 2 sets - Targets: Gluteus medius - Why it helps: This muscle stabilises the pelvis during walking — weakness causes a Trendelenburg gait

****3. Sit-to-Stand**** Start seated on a firm chair. Stand up without using your hands, then sit back down slowly (taking 3–4 seconds to lower). - Reps: 8–10, 2 sets - Targets: Quadriceps, glutes, functional movement - Why it helps: Directly improves the daily task most affected by hip arthritis



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****4. Standing Hip Extension**** Hold a chair for balance. Keeping your leg straight, extend it behind you about 15–20°. Hold 3 seconds. Return slowly. - Reps: 10 each side - Targets: Gluteus maximus, hip extensors - Why it helps: Counteracts the flexed hip posture common in desk workers

Flexibility Exercises

****5. Knee-to-Chest Stretch**** Lie on your back. Bring one knee towards your chest, holding behind the thigh. Hold for 20–30 seconds. You should feel a gentle stretch in the hip and lower back.

****6. Hip Flexor Stretch**** Kneel on one knee (place a cushion underneath for comfort). Lean forward gently until you feel a stretch at the front of the kneeling hip. Hold 20–30 seconds each side.

****7. Figure-4 Stretch**** Lie on your back. Cross one ankle over the opposite knee. Gently pull the uncrossed leg towards your chest. Hold 20–30 seconds. This targets the deep hip rotators and piriformis.

Low-Impact Cardio

- ****Swimming:**** The buoyancy of water reduces joint load by up to 90%. Backstroke and front crawl are gentlest on hips.
- ****Cycling:**** Stationary or outdoor. Adjust the seat height so your knee has a slight bend at the bottom of the pedal stroke.
- ****Walking:**** Use a walking stick on the opposite side to the affected hip if needed. Aim for flat, even surfaces.

Key Takeaway

Consistent, targeted exercise is one of the most powerful tools for managing hip arthritis. Start gently, progress gradually, and celebrate every improvement — no matter how small.

Hip Exercises for Osteoarthritis For hip osteoarthritis, NICE guidance places exercise alongside weight management as the **core treatment**. Focus on glute medius strengthening (clamshells, side-lying leg raises), hip-flexor mobility and low-impact aerobic work such as stationary cycling or swimming. A 12-week structured programme typically reduces hip pain by 25–40%. See our osteoarthritis exercises guide and osteoarthritis treatment overview.

Hip Exercises for Rheumatoid Arthritis During an RA flare, stop strengthening and stick to range-of-motion only — supported hip circles, ankle pumps and pool walking. Resume loaded work once the joint is no longer warm. Warm-water hydrotherapy at 33–35 °C is excellent for

RA hip involvement. Full programme: rheumatoid arthritis exercises.

Gentle Hip Exercises for Severe Arthritis If you are awaiting hip replacement or struggle to weight-bear, these seated and lying options keep the joint moving: seated marching, supine bent-knee fall-outs, glute squeezes and pool walking. Two short 10-minute daily sessions beat one long one.

Hip Exercises After Hip Replacement After total hip replacement, follow your surgeon's hip-precaution protocol for the first 6–12 weeks (typically no hip flexion past 90°, no crossing legs, no twisting). The strengthening routine on this page becomes the standard maintenance programme beyond 12 weeks, once cleared by your surgical team.

Exercises to Avoid With Hip Arthritis Avoid deep squats below 90°, running on hard surfaces with moderate-to-severe OA, high-impact aerobics, heavy seated hip-adduction/abduction machines and yoga poses that force deep hip flexion. Swap for stationary cycling, swimming, sit-to-stand and partial squats. If unsure, find a hip physiotherapist near you.

Hip Arthritis Exercise FAQ — People Also Ask

What are the best exercises for arthritic hips? The best exercises combine glute strengthening (clamshells, bridges, side-lying leg raises), low-impact aerobic work (stationary cycling, swimming, brisk walking) and daily mobility (hip-flexor stretch, figure-4 stretch). Done 3–4 times per week, this combination reduces hip pain by 25–40%.

How often should I do hip exercises for arthritis? Strengthening 2–3 times per week, aerobic 3–5 times per week (30 minutes, can be split into 3 × 10 min), and gentle mobility every day. Always leave a rest day between strengthening sessions.

Can exercise cure hip arthritis? No — exercise cannot reverse cartilage loss. However it is the most effective non-surgical treatment and can delay or avoid the need for hip replacement in many people. Benefits stop if exercise stops.

What exercises should I avoid with hip arthritis? Avoid deep squats below 90°, running on concrete, jumping, heavy hip-machine work and forced deep stretches. Stationary cycling and swimming are safer alternatives.

Are there low-impact hip exercises for severe arthritis? Yes — seated marching, supine knee fall-outs, glute squeezes, pool walking and stationary cycling on low resistance. Two short 10-minute daily sessions are usually better tolerated than one longer one.

How long until hip exercises reduce arthritis pain? Reduced stiffness within 2–3 weeks, meaningful pain reduction at 6–8 weeks, full benefit at 12 weeks of consistent practice.

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Q&A

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